6 Little Known Facts About César Chávez

(Source: Mother Nature Network)

César Chávez was one of the most prolific American social activists. In 1962, he founded the National Farm Workers Association, which was later changed to United Farm Workers or UFW. Chávez waged a nonviolent campaign for farm workers' rights that changed the American fabric.

1. He inspired Obama's *Yes, We Can* Campaign slogan

During a 25-day fast in 1972, Chávez and Huerta coined the slogan "Si, se puede," Spanish for "Yes, it can be done." It became the United Farm Workers' official motto and later inspired the phrase Yes, We Can for President's Obama's 2008 election campaign.

2. One of his 31 grandchildren is a pro golfer

Chávez and his wife, Helen Fabela, had eight children and 31 grandchildren. Professional golfer Sam Chávez, who plays on PGA Tour Canada, is the grandchild of Chávez.

3. A U.S. Navy cargo ship is named after him

He served two years in the U.S. Navy. Lewis and Clark-class cargo ships are named after American pioneers and visionaries, which is why the USNS César Chávez debuted in 2011. Chávez also has several American streets, schools and a national monument named after him.

4. He attended 38 different schools before 8th grade

As migrant farm workers, Chávez' family moved often. Chávez had to change schools 38 times before finally dropping out to help support his parents. Chávez later advocated education as a means for social improvement.

5. He fasted for 36 days at age 61 to protest pesticides

Under Chávez, the United Farm Workers helped secure union contracts that prohibited the use of DDT, required protective clothing to reduce workers' exposure to other pesticides and prevented spraying while workers were in the fields. He also fasted for 36 days in 1988 to protest pesticide use on grapes.

6. He was a vegetarian

"I became a vegetarian after realizing that animals feel afraid, cold, hungry and unhappy like we do," Chávez once said. "I feel very deeply about vegetarianism and the animal kingdom. It was my dog Boycott who led me to question the right of humans to eat other sentient beings."